

Maggie's Easter Journey

Five Days That Changed Everything

A Children's Book by Norman

Featuring Maggie the Yorkie Poo

"For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son,
that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life."

— **John 3:16**

How to Use This Book

Maggie's Easter Journey is designed to be read one chapter per day during Holy Week — the five days leading up to Easter Sunday. Each chapter tells a complete story from Maggie's perspective, and each story connects to a foundational truth from Scripture.

Read together as a family. After each chapter, use the Parent & Teacher Guide to discuss the biblical connection with your children. By Easter Sunday, the whole gospel story will be woven together in their hearts.

The Five-Day Reading Plan:

- **Monday of Holy Week — Chapter 1: The Broken Fence (Sin and Separation)**
- **Tuesday of Holy Week — Chapter 2: The Muddy Mess (We Cannot Save Ourselves)**
- **Wednesday of Holy Week — Chapter 3: The Dog Who Took Her Punishment (Substitution)**
- **Good Friday — Chapter 4: The Day Maggie Stopped Breathing (The Reality of Death)**
- **Easter Sunday Morning — Chapter 5: Maggie Waits at the Door (Resurrection!)**

Each chapter ends with a Key Verse, a Discussion Section for families, and an Illustration Note for artists.

Meet Maggie

Maggie is a small, fluffy Yorkie Poo with big brown eyes, silky golden-brown fur, and a personality that fills every room she enters. She loves morning walks, watching birds from the window, and most of all — being close to her family.

Maggie doesn't understand everything that happens around her, but she feels everything deeply. She notices when something is wrong. She notices when sadness fills the house. And she notices — more than anyone — when joy comes rushing back in.

Through Maggie's eyes, we will see the greatest story ever told in a way we may never have seen it before.

CHAPTER ONE

The Broken Fence

Why We Needed Saving

THE STORY

It was the most beautiful yard Maggie had ever seen. Green grass that tickled her paws. Flowers that smelled like heaven. And everywhere she looked — her family. Her owner's warm hands. The sound of her name being called in love.

But one afternoon, Maggie spotted something she had never noticed before — a small gap at the bottom of the fence. She sniffed it. She pawed at it. The gap grew wider.

"Just a quick look," she told herself.

She squeezed through — and the world outside was exciting and new. She ran and ran. But soon the streets all looked the same. The smells were wrong. The voices she heard weren't her family's voice. And no matter how hard she tried, she could not find her way home. The gap in the fence was gone. She had broken the fence coming through, and now it was sealed shut — and she was on the wrong side.

Maggie sat down in the middle of a strange street and did the only thing she could do. She cried.

She couldn't undo what she'd done. She couldn't fix the fence from the outside. She was lost — and she had done it to herself.

Then she heard it. A voice. Her owner's voice. Calling her name. Running down the street toward her. The reunion was so joyful that Maggie couldn't stop shaking. And when they got home, her owner repaired the fence — not Maggie, not even a little bit. Her owner did it all.

THE BIBLICAL CONNECTION

Primary Text: Genesis 3 — The Fall

Adam and Eve lived in perfect relationship with God — a beautiful garden, His presence, His voice. Their disobedience broke the fence. Separation entered the world. And just like Maggie, no matter what they tried, they could not fix what they had broken. God came searching.

Supporting Text: Luke 15:11-24 — The Prodigal Son

The son who ran away couldn't earn his way back. The father ran to meet him. This is the posture of God toward every lost person — not waiting, but running.

KEY VERSE

"For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God." — Romans 3:23

PARENT & TEACHER DISCUSSION GUIDE

- Why did Maggie go through the fence? Did she know it might separate her from her family?
- What does sin mean? Can you think of a time you did something that felt like it put a wall between you and someone you love?
- Who fixed the fence — Maggie or her owner? Why couldn't Maggie fix it herself?
- Read Genesis 3:8-9. What did God do after Adam and Eve sinned? What does that tell us about Him?

ILLUSTRATION NOTE

Scene 1: Maggie in the beautiful yard, close to her family, golden light. **Scene 2:** Maggie squeezing through the gap. **Scene 3:** Maggie alone on a dark street, looking small and lost. **Scene 4:** Owner running toward Maggie, arms wide open.

CHAPTER TWO

The Muddy Mess

We Cannot Save Ourselves

THE STORY

It started with one small mud puddle.

Maggie stepped in it. Then another. Then somehow, before she knew what was happening, she had rolled through the worst mud in the entire neighborhood — thick, black, terrible mud that clung to every strand of her silky fur. She smelled awful. She looked worse.

She had to get clean before her family saw her. She rubbed herself against the green grass — still dirty. She tried the rough doormat — still dirty. She rolled in a pile of dry leaves — somehow even dirtier. She tried running fast enough that maybe the wind would clean her off. It did not.

Every single thing she tried to fix herself only made it worse, or moved the mud around, or added new problems on top of the old ones.

Finally, completely exhausted, she sat at the back door and whimpered.

Her owner opened the door, took one look at Maggie's muddy mess, and didn't hesitate for a single second. She scooped Maggie up — mud and all — carried her to the bathtub, and washed her completely clean. Not mostly clean. Completely clean. Down to the roots of every strand of fur.

Maggie hadn't earned it. She couldn't have. The only way to get clean was to stop trying and let someone else do it.

THE BIBLICAL CONNECTION

Primary Text: Isaiah 64:6 — Our Efforts Are Not Enough

The prophet Isaiah wrote that all our righteous acts — our very best attempts to make ourselves right — are like filthy rags before a holy God. This is not discouraging. It is liberating. It means we don't have to exhaust ourselves trying to earn what we can only receive.

Supporting Text: Luke 18:9-14 — The Pharisee and the Tax Collector

The Pharisee tried every spiritual technique to clean himself up. The tax collector stopped trying and simply cried out for mercy. Jesus said the tax collector went home clean. Surrender is not weakness. It is the door.

KEY VERSE

"For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith — and this is not from yourselves, it is the gift of God — not by works, so that no one can boast." — **Ephesians 2:8-9**

PARENT & TEACHER DISCUSSION GUIDE

- Why didn't any of Maggie's cleaning ideas work? What does that feel like — trying hard and still failing?
- Have you ever tried really hard to be good enough? What happened?
- What does grace mean? How is grace different from earning something?

- Why did Maggie finally get clean? What did she have to do first?

ILLUSTRATION NOTE

Scene 1: Maggie stepping into a mud puddle with a look of surprise. Scene 2: A sequence of four small panels showing each failed attempt. Scene 3: Maggie sitting at the door, defeated and filthy. Scene 4: Owner holding clean, fluffy Maggie wrapped in a white towel — both glowing.

CHAPTER THREE

The Dog Who Took Her Punishment

Someone Else Had to Pay

THE STORY

Maggie did something she was not supposed to do.

She had been told — very clearly, many times — that the beautiful leather book on the coffee table was not for chewing. But one afternoon, when no one was watching, she gave in. She chewed the corner. Then a little more. By the time she realized what she had done, the damage was real and there was no hiding it.

Maggie panicked and hid behind the couch.

When the family found the book, they looked around the room. Maggie's heart hammered. But Bailey — the gentle, older dog who had done nothing wrong — was standing closest to the book. Bailey was scolded. Bailey was sent to his bed in the corner. Bailey, who was completely innocent, sat quietly and accepted what happened. He looked at Maggie with his soft brown eyes. Not with anger. Just with sadness — and something that looked almost like love.

Maggie lay behind the couch feeling the weight of the worst guilt she had ever known. She had done it. Bailey was suffering for what SHE had done.

Eventually, the truth came out. When Maggie crept out from behind the couch and confessed — not in words, but in the way only dogs can confess — Bailey was immediately restored. Brought back. Celebrated. And Maggie understood something she would never forget: an innocent one had suffered in her place. And when the truth came to light, restoration followed.

THE BIBLICAL CONNECTION

Primary Text: Isaiah 53:4-6 — The Suffering Servant

Hundreds of years before Jesus was born, Isaiah described someone who would take the punishment of others on himself — wounded for our wrongdoing, crushed for our guilt, the punishment that should have fallen on us falling on him instead. This is the clearest Old Testament picture of what Jesus would do on the cross.

Supporting Text: Matthew 27:15-26 — Barabbas

Barabbas was guilty. Jesus was innocent. The crowd chose to release Barabbas and crucify Jesus. A guilty man walked free. The innocent One took his place. This is not merely a historical event — it is a picture of every person who has ever been separated from God. We are Barabbas.

KEY VERSE

**"But he was pierced for our transgressions, he was crushed for our iniquities; the punishment that brought us peace was on him, and by his wounds we are healed."
— Isaiah 53:5**

PARENT & TEACHER DISCUSSION GUIDE

- How do you think Maggie felt watching Bailey be punished for what she did?
- Who is Barabbas in the Easter story? Who does he represent?
- Why did Jesus have to be innocent for the substitution to work?
- When you picture yourself as Maggie in this story — and Jesus as Bailey — how does that change the way you think about the cross?

ILLUSTRATION NOTE

Scene 1: Maggie chewing the book, looking guilty. Scene 2: Bailey standing by the book, confused, while the family looks at him. Scene 3: Bailey in the corner, eyes meeting Maggie's — soft, not angry. Scene 4: Maggie coming out from behind the couch, and Bailey being joyfully restored.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Day Maggie Stopped Breathing

The Death Was Real

A NOTE TO PARENTS BEFORE THIS CHAPTER

This chapter handles death gently but honestly. It is designed for children ages 6-12 who are ready to understand that the death of Jesus was not symbolic — it was real, complete, and devastating to those who loved Him. Read together and give your child space to feel the weight of this before the joy of Chapter Five.

THE STORY

For three days, something was terribly wrong.

Maggie had gotten very sick — sick in a way that nothing could fix quickly. The house became quiet in a way it had never been quiet before. The family moved carefully, spoke softly. Maggie lay still. Her breathing was so faint that sometimes the children would lean close just to make sure she was still there.

The toys in the corner sat untouched. The food bowl stayed full. The leash hung on the hook without being reached for. Everything that had been full of life and movement and joy was completely still.

The children cried. The parents sat quietly with them. Nobody pretended it wasn't hard. Nobody said "don't be sad." Because the sadness was real. And the stillness was real. And love never makes the grief of loss smaller — it makes it bigger.

This is what Saturday felt like for the disciples.

They had watched Jesus die. Really die. The tomb was sealed and guarded. Mary had bought spices to anoint a body — not because she expected a miracle, but because she expected only a burial. Saturday was the most silent, most hopeless day in the history of the world. The disciples didn't gather together with expectation. They hid behind locked doors in fear.

The death was not a symbol. It was not a sleep. It was complete. And it had to be — because what was coming next could only mean something as big as the grief that came before it.

THE BIBLICAL CONNECTION

Primary Text: John 11:1-44 — The Death and Resurrection of Lazarus

Before He raised Lazarus, Jesus stood at the tomb and wept. He let the grief be completely real. He did not rush past it or minimize it. He entered it — and then He transformed it. This is the pattern of God: He does not deny our pain. He redeems it.

Supporting Text: Luke 23:50-56 — Holy Saturday

The women who loved Jesus prepared burial spices. The disciples scattered and hid. The Sabbath came. And they rested — not in peace, but in grief. The stone was sealed. All hope appeared to be over. This day must not be skipped in our telling of Easter. Sunday means nothing without Saturday.

KEY VERSE

"Jesus wept." — **John 11:35**

"And if Christ has not been raised, your faith is futile; you are still in your sins." — **1 Corinthians 15:17**

PARENT & TEACHER DISCUSSION GUIDE

- **How did the house feel different when Maggie was sick? Why does love make grief feel bigger, not smaller?**
- **Why is it important that Jesus really died — not just seemed to die?**
- **What do you think Saturday felt like for Mary and the disciples?**
- **Read John 11:35 — the shortest verse in the Bible. What does it tell us about Jesus that He cried?**

ILLUSTRATION NOTE

Scene 1: The quiet house — empty food bowl, untouched toys, leash on the hook. Scene 2: Children sitting quietly, parents nearby. Scene 3: A single candle burning low in the dark. Scene 4: A sealed stone tomb at twilight — purple and gray sky, one lone figure walking away.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Door Swings Open

He Is Risen — And Everything Changes

THE STORY

On the morning of the third day, something happened.

The children were asleep. The house was still gray with early morning light. And then — movement. The tiniest sound. A tapping at the back door.

The youngest child heard it first and ran to the door. And there — standing on the back porch, tail going so fast it was a blur, eyes bright, paws dancing — was Maggie. Completely well. Not just better. Fully, completely, impossibly well.

The child screamed. The whole family came running. There was crying that sounded exactly like laughing. There was laughing that sounded exactly like crying. Maggie ran in circles so fast that she crashed into the couch twice and didn't care at all. The food bowl was filled. The leash came off the hook. The toys were everywhere.

Everything that had been still was in motion. Everything that had been silent was full of sound. Everything that had been empty was overflowing.

This is what Sunday morning felt like.

Mary came to the tomb in the dark, carrying her spices, expecting only to find a body. Instead she found an empty tomb — and then she heard her name. One word. "Mary." And she knew. She ran. She couldn't contain it. The disciples, hiding behind locked doors in fear, suddenly had a risen Jesus standing in the room with them — and fear became joy so big it couldn't fit inside them.

Now — look back at all five chapters and see what happened:

- The fence that was broken? Jesus repaired it. The way back to God is open.
- The mud that couldn't be cleaned? His blood washes completely clean.
- The punishment we deserved? He took it. We are free.
- The death that was so terribly real? He defeated it. Death is not the end.
- The door we waited at in grief? He opened it from the other side.

This is Easter. This is the gospel. And because it is true — everything changes.

THE BIBLICAL CONNECTION

Primary Text: John 20:1-18 — The Empty Tomb and Mary's Encounter

Mary stood outside the tomb weeping, believing all hope was gone — and heard her name spoken by the risen Jesus. That moment of recognition is the door swinging open. Notice that Jesus called her by name. He calls each of us by name.

Supporting Text: Luke 24:13-35 — The Road to Emmaus

Two disciples walked away from Jerusalem in complete despair — and Jesus walked alongside them the entire time without them recognizing Him. When their eyes were finally opened, they ran back to Jerusalem. We are often walking the Emmaus road ourselves, not recognizing that He is already with us.

Looking Forward: Revelation 3:20 — He Still Knocks

The door image comes full circle. Jesus says, "Here I am! I stand at the door and knock." The resurrection is not only a past event — it is a present invitation. He is risen, and He is still at the door.

KEY VERSE

"Jesus said to her, 'Mary.' She turned toward him and cried out in Aramaic, 'Rabboni!' (which means Teacher)." — John 20:16

PARENT & TEACHER DISCUSSION GUIDE

- When Maggie came back, how did the children respond? What did the house feel like?
- Why do you think Jesus said Mary's name? What does it mean that He knows your name?
- Look back through all five chapters together. Can you find the broken fence, the mud, the punishment, the death, and the door in the Easter story?
- What does the resurrection change about how we face hard things in our own lives?
- Revelation 3:20 says Jesus is knocking at the door of our hearts. What does it mean to open the door?

ILLUSTRATION NOTE

Scene 1: Pre-dawn darkness with a faint golden light at the horizon. Scene 2: A child flinging open the door to find Maggie — pure joy explosion. Scene 3: The whole family in joyful chaos, Maggie in the center. Scene 4: The empty tomb at sunrise — stone rolled away, golden light flooding out, one figure standing in the light.

The Complete Gospel Arc

For parents and teachers: here is the complete theological journey of the five chapters side by side.

Chapter	Gospel Truth	Primary Scripture	Key Verse
1 — The Broken Fence	Sin separates us from God	Genesis 3 / Luke 15:11-24	Romans 3:23
2 — The Muddy Mess	We cannot save ourselves	Isaiah 64:6 / Luke 18:9-14	Ephesians 2:8-9
3 — The Dog Who Took Her Punishment	Jesus took our punishment	Isaiah 53:5-6 / Matthew 27:15-26	Isaiah 53:5
4 — The Day Maggie Stopped	The death was real and complete	John 11 / Luke 23:50-56	John 11:35
5 — The Door Swings Open	The resurrection changes everything	John 20:1-18 / Luke 24:13-35	John 20:16

A Prayer to Close

For families to pray together on Easter morning

Heavenly Father,

Thank You for not leaving us on the wrong side of the fence. Thank You that no mess we could ever make is too much for Your grace to wash clean. Thank You that You took our punishment — that You are both perfectly just and perfectly loving.

Thank You that the death was real — because that means the resurrection was real.

And thank You that the door is open. Help us walk through it — today and every day.

In the name of Jesus, who is risen indeed. Amen.

He is risen.

He is risen indeed.